

TOWARD A QUALITY FAMILY LIFE

In 1969 the North Pole Santa Claus Company hired me as a department-store Santa Claus. Kids on Santa's lap yank, grab, cry, spit, and steal candy canes. So, before sending the new recruits to the front, the North Pole Santa Claus Company gave us a short training session.

We learned that Santa should get little Junior on his lap, find out what he wants for Christmas, and get him off his lap. Santa must avoid at all costs anything that interferes with that neat, speedy process. We learned, for example, never to ask a kid's name. Kids want to tell Santa the presents they want, not their names. Santa can waste valuable time cajoling a name out of a child who has other things on his mind. It's better to call all boys Junior and all girls Sister.

We learned that Santa should end each lap visit the same way: "Your old buddy Santa can't promise anything. But if you behave, and obey your folks, Santa will do the best he can."

The key word here is *folks*. One of the most dangerous things Santa can do is tell a child to obey "mommy and daddy." In 1969 a third of the children likely to wind up on Santa's lap were living with a mommy or a daddy but not both. If Santa says "obey mommy and daddy," a good number of those kids will well up with tears and stammer, "I don't have a daddy." Once a kid starts to cry, others follow. The chain reaction results in the kind of pandemonium Santa wants to avoid.

I remember being shocked, in 1969, that so many children lived with only one parent. Now we take it as the norm. We know that children do better living with both parents, or at least with two married adults. Yet, Americans continue to destroy family units in record numbers. Foreigners look to the United States as a wealthy, progressive country. But if you ask them to trade their family life for what we have in the United States, they'd say, "No, thanks."

Retirement doesn't guarantee a happy family life. But re-